

6.2 Viruses



Virus attacks harm the internet community

Every computer user is aware of the damage a virus can inflict on their system. Part of the legendary status a computer virus enjoys today is thanks to the way it is depicted in fiction; whether movies or books. So what really is this virtual being that can damage your system and spread from one computer to another quite in the same way as its real world counterpart?

The main criterion for classifying a piece of executable code as a virus is that it should spread by means of 'hosts'. A virus can only spread from one computer to another when its host is taken to the uninfected computer; in most cases, by a user sending it over a network. Additionally, viruses can spread to other computers by infecting files on a network file system or a file system that is accessed by another computer.

In many cases, viruses are confused with worms. A worm, however, can spread itself to other computers without needing to be transferred as part of a host. Many personal computers are now con-